

and gain inspiration for what could come next. Asking the right questions and listening actively is crucial in these conversations to get the information you need.

The Interview Carousel is a lightweight, fun way to practice and enhance user interviewing skills for GitLab team members. Everyone can be a great interviewer, however, we are not necessarily born as one. It takes a little bit of practice, and that's what the Interview Carousel is for.

The setup

The Interview Carousel is a live (remote) event where team members get to speak with 3 to 4 users each. Imagine a speed-dating style setup where you speak with one user for 15 minutes and then switch to the next one. There are small breaks in between to avoid fatigue.

Discussion topics

As an Interview Carousel participant, you choose what you'd like to discuss with users. You can bring a prototype or talk about a specific item you are working (or planning to work) on. Alternately, you can simply learn more about that person, their job, and their life. Remember, it's only 15 minutes per person, which goes by quickly. We aim to match you with users that represent the persona(s) of your stage.

How do I prepare?

There is a 20-minute video that you must watch before the event that includes tips and tricks on how to be a better interviewer. As you are watching the video, note the 2 or 3 things that you want to focus on and practice during the Interview Carousel.

Make sure to draft a discussion guide (internal only) for your session and share it for feedback with the UX Researcher who is hosting the Interview Carousel. This helps to ensure that participants won't answer the same questions again and again.

You should set aside about 1 hour to watch the training video and create your discussion guide.

What happens after the event?

To make the most out of the event, we strongly encourage you to record your interviews and upload them to Dovetail. The UX Researcher hosting the Interview Carousel will watch the recordings and provide you with individual feedback on your interviewing skills.

How do I join?

The next Interview Carousel is happening in January 2023. If you are interested in joining, fill out the interest form.

Why should I join?

Below are some verbatims that GitLab team members who previously participated in an Interview Carousel shared about their experience joining.

"This process made me more aware of ways that questions can be leading and ways to avoid it, especially in follow-up questions (it's hard!)."

"The video material was really good and helped to clarify my goals for every interview since then."

"This was the first opportunity I came across in my entire career as a designer to get my interviewing style assessed and get feedback."

"Valuable feedback! I usually don't notice I'm asking leading questions, so it's great to have it called out."

Frequently Asked Questions

1. Do you have any example discussion guides that I can learn from?

You can review previous Interview Carousel issues that have discussion guides linked. There is also a collection of discussion guides written by the UX Research team that may serve as inspiration.

1. How are transitions between interviews handled?

The UX Researcher sets up Zoom breakout rooms and assigns team members and participants to the rooms. The break out rooms will close after 15 minutes. Once everyone is back in the main room, the UX Researcher will re-assign participants.

1. Who moderates the session?

The UX Researcher moderates the Interview Carousel and provides a general introduction at the beginning that includes confirming participants' consent to record the session and provides details regarding the incentive.

SECTION: product/ux/ux-research/problem-validation-and-methods.md

At GitLab, we practice both Problem Validation research and Solution Validation research, depending on the questions we need answers to and where we are in the design process. The end result of these methods is a high degree of confidence which results in a better overall user experience. Generating solutions, developing the product experience, and launching to the market is much more effective when we start with a deep understanding of our customer problems. We leverage Opportunity Canvases to track quick iterations on levels of confidence, hypotheses, and lessons learned as our learning about the problem evolves.

What is problem validation?

Problem validation research seeks to provide decision makers with a well understood and clearly articulated customer problem. At GitLab, problem validation encompasses foundational research as well as descriptive and informative research.

- Foundational research helps develop a deeper understanding of users to uncover opportunities for solutions and innovation.

- Descriptive and informative research begins with a problem statement in mind and is used to gain a detailed understanding of the context of the problem.

When to use problem validation?

Problem validation happens earlier on in the product life cycle when we want to get insight into a problem and scope down the focus of a problem.

Foundational research is done when we don't have a good understanding of what the problem is we need to solve. Often this occurs at the very beginning of the product design process. The purpose is to formulate a problem to solve and have a decent level of confidence that the problem is a relevant one.

Descriptive and informative research starts with a problem statement, which provides us a concrete problem to solve. This research is used to gain a better understanding of the context we are trying to solve for through our design and is imperative to fill the knowledge gaps of the solution environment by what our participants know.

When you are conducting a problem validation research effort, make sure to apply the UX Problem Validation label to the research issue.

What questions can problem validation answer?

Foundational research provides answers to these questions:

- Is there a problem? If so, what is it?
- Who are the users?
- What are the users' mental models as they relate to the problem(s)?

Descriptive and informative research provides answers to these questions:

- What are the pain points today?
- How do users feel about it?
- How is this done today?
- Why is it done this way?

Problem validation methods & when to use them

When choosing the right method for problem validation research, first ask yourself if you need foundational or informative research.

- Foundational research helps develop a deeper understanding of users to uncover opportunities for solutions and innovation.
- Descriptive and informative research begins with a problem statement in mind and is used to gain a detailed understanding of the context of the problem.

Problem validation research is not only conducted with end users. Often, sales, support, and CSMs (technical account managers) can offer valuable insights into customer behavior. They typically interact with a large number of customers and have a well developed understanding of what needs customers have and what issues they have faced.

Foundational research methods

To choose the right foundational research method, you need to identify the purpose for your research. Ask yourself "Why am I doing this research?" Your answer will help you choose which method to use. You should also ask yourself how much detail you need, what kind of participants you need, and the fidelity of insight you require. If you are still unsure, please reach out to your UX Researcher.

	Overall Purpose for Research
Research Method	
:----- :-----	
- Understand a phenomenon - Expand a theory - Challenge the dominant view - Propose a new theory - Justify the need for a new technology	
Diary study Contextual inquiry	
- Redesign a product - Make a technology more usable/accessible/inclusive - Innovate - Solve a new problem	
Contextual inquiry	Diary study Contextual inquiry
- Motivate change - Empower people - Increase visibility and scrutiny - Apply a critical lens	
Contextual inquiry In-depth interview	

Descriptive and informative research methods

To choose the right descriptive and informative research method, ask yourself, "What do I need to understand better?" Your answer will help you choose which method to use. If you are still unsure, please reach out to your UX Researcher.

	What I need to understand better
Research Method	
:----- :-----	
- How users perform in their natural environment - What tools they use - How their space is set up	
Contextual inquiry	
What users' attitudes, beliefs, desires, and experiences are	
In-depth interview	
How users complete tasks over an extended period of time (hours, days or weeks)	
Diary study	
How my customers might solve product problems for themselves	
Participatory design	
What the entire experience is from the user's standpoint	
User journey mapping	

Check out our guidance for writing your discussion guide and facilitating user sessions for In-depth interviews.

You can also frame questions using the Taxonomy of Cognitive Domain, which explains how certain verbs target particular thought processes. This is a great way to expand your questioning in order to help trigger specific responses from participants.

Domain	Critical Thinking Process	Verbs to use
Sample Questions		

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|-----|-----|-----|
|-----|-----|-----|
|-----|-----|-----|
| Knowledge | Remembering <br>Memorizing <br>Recognizing | Who <br>What <br>When
<br>Where <br>How | <ul><li>What do you like about how you currently
[problem/task]?</li> <li>What is the biggest pain point related to [problem/task]?</li>
<li>Tell me about the last time you tried to [problem/task].</li> <li>How much time do you
typically spend on [problem/task]?</li></ul> |
| Comprehension | Interpreting <br>Translating <br>Describing | Explain <br>Outline
<br>Distinguish <br>Compare <br>Define | <ul><li>Why is [problem/task] important to you?
</li></ul>
|
| Application | Problem-solving <br>Applying information | Show <br>Use <br>Complete
<br>Classify <br>Relate | <ul><li>Show me how you currently go about
[problem/task].</li></ul>
|
| Analysis | Separating <br>Finding structure | Contrast <br>Categorize
<br>Identify <br>Separate <br>Diagram | <ul><li>What type of workarounds have you created to
help with [problem/task]?</li> <li>What do you like or dislike about these other products or
tools?</li> <li>What's the hardest part about [problem/task]?</li></ul>
|
| Synthesis | Creating <br>Combining | Create <br>Imagine <br>Design
<br>Propose <br>Invent | <ul><li>Create your ideal pipeline status page. Explain your
design.</li></ul>
|
| Evaluation | Judging <br>Resolving | Select <br>Decide <br>Prioritize
<br>Rate <br>Discuss | <ul><li>Rank the following features in order of their usefulness
to you in completing your tasks. Explain your answers. </li></ul>
|

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SECTION: product/ux/ux-research/problem-validation-single-stage-group.md

Single-stage-group research initiatives deal with specific behaviors that relate to only one stage group, such as "How do Release Managers do their job?".

To get started, follow the initial steps outlined in the Product handbook.

For user interviews

1. Product Manager drafts the discussion guide. When a first draft of the guide is complete, the UX Researcher reviews and provides feedback.
1. Simultaneously, the UX Researcher begins crafting a screening survey in Qualtrics.
1. After the screening survey is created, the UX Researcher will open a Recruiting request issue using the available template in the UX Research project and assign it to the Research Coordinator.
1. The Research Coordinator will perform a sense check to make sure your screener will catch

the people you've identified as your target participants. If there are multiple rounds of review, the Coordinator will pause activities until uncertainty about your screening criteria has been resolved.

1. By default, Product Managers are responsible for leading (moderating) problem validation interviews with users. If the study is complex in nature, a UX Researcher may volunteer to moderate. UX Researchers have the discretion to decide which research studies they will moderate and which they will observe synchronously or asynchronously.

1. The person who is leading the interviews, and who has subsequently supplied their Calendly link to the Research Coordinator, is responsible for creating user interview invites on the UX Research calendar (gitlab.comkieqv96j35mpt8bdkcbriu2qbg@group.calendar.google.com). Other interested parties (Product Designers, Product Managers, UX Researchers, etc) are encouraged to subscribe to the calendar.

1. After the interviews are concluded, the UX Researcher updates the Recruiting request. The Research Coordinator will reimburse participants for their time within 2 business days of the interview.

1. Product Manager and UX Researcher work collaboratively to synthesize the data and identify trends in Dovetail, resulting in insights.

1. UX Researcher updates the Problem validation research issue with links to findings in Dovetail and, if applicable, unmarks the Problem validation research issue as confidential before closing it.

For surveys

1. The Product Manager drafts the survey. When a first draft of the survey is complete, the UX Researcher reviews and provides feedback.

1. The UX Researcher enters the survey in Qualtrics.

1. Once the survey has been entered into Qualtrics, the UX Researcher opens a Recruiting request issue using the available template in the UX Research project and assigns it to the relevant Research Coordinator.

1. The Research Coordinator distributes the survey to a sample of participants.

1. The UX Researcher, will review the responses received so far and amend the survey if necessary. The UX Researcher should advise the Research Coordinator when to continue recruitment.

1. The UX Researcher will keep the Research Coordinator informed of the survey's response rate and must notify them when they plan to close the survey (to ensure recruitment doesn't continue on a survey that has been closed).

1. After the survey is closed, the UX Researcher updates the Recruiting request issue. The Research Coordinator will reimburse selected participants for their time (payment occurs on Tuesdays and Thursdays).

1. Product Manager and UX Researcher work collaboratively to synthesize the data and identify trends, resulting in insights.

1. UX Researcher documents insights in Dovetail.

1. UX Researcher updates the Problem validation research issue with links to findings in Dovetail and, if applicable, unmarks the Problem validation research issue as confidential before closing it.

SECTION: `product/ux/ux-research/research-panel-management.md`

A research panel is a frequently used means for recruiting participants when conducting research consisting of studying the same group of opted-in participants through various methods and stages that are developed as part of a research effort. This page walks through a self-service process to create and manage panels.

When should I use a research panel?

Recruiting participants for research with niche topics can take a lot of time and effort to find. Frequency, subject-matter, scope, and scale are all areas of consideration as to when a panel may be needed. If you have a need for a larger group surrounding a certain niche criteria focusing on an issue (that will contain multiple research studies) over a longer period of time, this would be a time to consider using a panel. For example, larger enterprise users or users that are on Ultimate that have experience using a SAST tool and a role that involves using security tools or practices.

It is also important to consider the various pros and cons when utilizing a panel:

Pros:

- Opportunity to follow the same participants over multiple research initiatives to assist with tracking trends and changes throughout time and different product areas.
- Better chance of gaining in-depth knowledge and an understanding of your participants through their consistent involvement with the research.
- Ability to recruit participants on an expedited timeline, especially when you have a difficult or niche user profile.

Cons:

- Participant fatigue if users are contacted too frequently about participating in studies, which may also lead to having to refresh panel participants.
- Bias may begin to occur if the same people are surveyed multiple times, possibly causing us to over-index on feedback from a few users, instead of representing as many users as possible. Participants may also begin to recognize your research patterns and respond in a less natural manner.
- Periodically having to update the panel to ensure the appropriate participants are still included and there is an appropriate mix of individuals.

Initially, answering the following questions will help determine whether a panel is the right solution for your project.

- Why do you need a panel?
 - It's best use a panel for users who are typically hard to recruit, either because there aren't many of them (for example, Enterprise users), because they have attributes that are specialized and make them harder to find (for example, extensive experience with Kubernetes), or because they have been harder for us to recruit in the past (for example, self-managed users).
- How long will this panel need to be sustained?
 - For panels to be the most effective, setting a duration is crucial to ensure you are not over-indexing on feedback from a few users which will bias your results. Research Operations recommends a panel to last no longer than 6 months to help ensure that you are not over-

indexing on panel participants.

- How large will the panel need to be?

- Start with an idea of how large your panel needs to be. This will depend on the goals of the panel and the frequency of participant sessions. As a data point for general guidance, previous panel sizes created by UX Researchers ranged from 30-500 panelists.

- Will you be able to frequently communicate with the panelists to keep them engaged?

A panel is a commitment. You will need to ensure you have the capacity to maintain communication and engage with the panelists on the schedule provided to them upon registration.

Suggested communication cadence:

- Upon selection: When panelists are selected to participate in the panel, let them know what to expect.

- Monthly: This could include updates about the research effort or upcoming research sessions.

- Conclusion: When the panel is no longer needed.

How do I create and conduct research using a panel?

Establish a DRI for the panel

Before creating a panel, you will need to establish a Panel DRI. This person is responsible for steps within the creation of the panel, communicating with participants, and panel management and tracking.

Creating a panel

To create a panel, follow the steps below. If you have any questions, please contact a UX Research Operations Coordinator to assist you.

1. Determine panelist criteria

- Review this link for information on how to assist in selecting criteria to identify participants.

- Who does this: Research project DRI

1. Set a timeline for how long you plan to maintain and use the panel

- The longer a panel runs, the higher the likelihood of overusing the same participants increases.

- Who does this: Research project DRI

1. Find your participants by creating a research recruitment request

- To populate your panel, open a research recruitment request and indicate that the request is for a research panel.

- You can find participants yourself and skip this step.

- Who does this: Panel DRI and Research Operations

1. Decide who will be in your panel and use the Panel Tracking & Reimbursement Template to compile participants

- After respondents complete the screener, you will need to review responses and determine who qualifies for the panel based on your criteria.

- Add the panelists and their information in the Panelist Information sheet in the Panel Tracking & Reimbursement Template. To do so, download the results from Qualtrics and transfer to the Panelist Information sheet.

- Who does this: Panel DRI

1. Communicate with participants regarding their inclusion in the panel, who their point of contact will be for the research effort, and frequency and length of participation. Refer to Communication guidelines for participant outreach.

- Who does this: Panel DRI
- See Participant email communication examples for templates.

Conducting research with your panel

After you have established your panel, follow these steps to utilize panel participants.

1. Identify participants you want to reach out to in your panel

- Sometimes you may want to use a mixture of panelists and other recruitment methods for a study.

- Check in the Panel Tracking & Reimbursement template to see how many times they have participated in previous studies. If they have already participated in (4) 60-minute sessions during the calendar year, remove them from the panel.

- Who does this: Panel DRI

1. Schedule your sessions

- Schedule your sessions using Calendly. Here is an email template you can use when scheduling sessions with panelists.

- Who does this: Panel DRI

1. Compensate your participants by submitting a incentives request

- To compensate panelists as they participate in studies, follow our existing process for incentives by submitting an incentives request.

- Who does this: Panel DRI

As you use your panel, you will need to continually manage and track panelist information and engagement. Refer to the Panel management and tracking section.

Guidelines when communicating with panelists

One goal of a panel is to keep participants engaged and not to incur fatigue from over communication to where they no longer want to participate. Below are some guidelines on how to communicate with your panel:

- Outline communication guidelines initially within the recruiting screener, such as how often they'll be contacted, who will contact them, how they'll be contacted, and how team members will coordinate contact. To stay within your guidelines, set up reminders on your Google calendar.

- Consistency is key. If you communicate to participants that they will receive a total of three communications a month, send no less than and no more than three. Detouring from the set expectations could potentially make the panelist think that the research is not organized or serious, causing disengagement.

- Track how often we're communicating with panelists in the Panel Tracking & Reimbursement Template. Do not reach out more than once a month to panelists.

- If participants contact the designated point of contact, you must reply in a 24-hour time window if it is during the week (otherwise, the next business day will suffice). It is a top priority to be responsive and consistently engaged.

- When the designated point of contact goes on PTO, ensure there is someone to cover communication with panelists.

Panel management and tracking

Once you have surveyed and compiled the list of participants that you will include in your research effort, you will be required to track all panelist activity related to communications, participation, and incentives.

To manage your panel, use the Panel Tracking & Reimbursement Template. This spreadsheet will encompass all information surrounding each panelist, their activities, and the reimbursements they receive while the panel is active.

How to use the spreadsheet:

There are three individual sheets in the tracker spreadsheet.

- The Panelist Information sheet contains all panel participants and their general survey information from the initial screener. You will use this sheet to store information on panelists and to source participants. The first line of the template is filled in as an example.

- The columns include:

- First name

- Last name

- Email

- Sign-up source (i.e, Qualtrics, CSMs)

- Country

- Outreach total - Automatically updated column that shows the total number of outreaches that the participant has received.

- Session total - Automatically updated column that shows the total number of sessions the participant has been in. The cell highlights as orange when a panelist has participated in 3 sessions and red if the participant has been in 4 sessions.

- Participant rating - Provide a general rating describing their participation.

- Notes - Provide additional information on how the participant did in the session and reasoning why or about why not to use them again, along with other items worth mentioning that could be pertinent to the research.

- Job title or persona

- Screener response/demographics - These columns are unlimited, and you may tailor them to your specific screener. Consider adding the attributes you care about most in the first columns, such as company size, industry, and so on. Track additional columns to ensure you have a diverse panel. These may vary from panel to panel or across stage groups.

- The Panelist Reimbursement sheet will be used in coordination with Research Operations for reimbursements and to track the number of sessions a panelist participates in. The first line is filled in as an example.

- The columns include:

- First name

- Last Name

- Email Address

- Project DRI

- Research Issue

- Session Length

- Amount

- Country

- Paid - to be completed post session
- Participation Date - A new line will be created for a participant for each different date they participated.
- The Outreach sheet is used to track every panelist outreach. You will need to paste in panelist information each time you send outreach communication. It will automatically update summary information in the Panelist Information sheet.
- The columns include:
 - Email
 - Date
 - Outreach type
 - Notes

To avoid exceeding a total \$600 gratuity per year per participant, a panelist may only participate in four 60-minute sessions per fiscal year. Once a panelist has reached four 60-minute sessions per calendar-year limit, they are no longer eligible to participate in studies. Remove the panelist from the panel and communicate to them that they are no longer eligible.

To keep the Panel Tracking & Reimbursement Template in a secure location, you will need to store your sheet in the Research Panels folder in the UX Research Google Shared Drive. Share settings should be restricted to the team members that need the required access.

Managing personally identifiable information (PII)

When managing panels, you are responsible for protecting Personally Identifiable Information (PII). Typically, this is done by Research Operations, but when teams are self-creating their own panels, they are responsible for managing the participants and their associated PII. Review best practices for data that is classified as ORANGE, and familiarize yourself with this overview of PII.

Always follow these best practices for handling PII within panels:

- Only collect the minimal amount of information you need for a person. Data you will likely collect:
 - First name
 - Last name
 - Email
 - Sign-up source (i.e, Qualtrics, CSMS)
 - Country
 - Job title or persona
 - Screener response/demographics

Do not collect data just to have it available for a non-specific purpose. For example, do not collect "time in a role" if role tenure is not relevant to the research effort.

- If someone is working from a public workspace, screens should not show panel information.
- Report any compromised data (see GitLab's data classification) by creating a security incident.
- Remember to follow GitLab's privacy policy.
- Participants may request

- To be removed from the panel: Remove them, and then reach out to a Research Operations team member to ensure they are removed from other active panels and other communications.
- To see their personal data: They can submit a Personal data request to see which lists they are subscribed to. Reach out to a Research Operations team member to help with this request.

What is an example of a panel in action at GitLab?

Here is an example of a panel used by Verify and Package. The team created this issue to draft a common screener for a panel that they could use across multiple studies to expedite recruitment efforts. In this scenario, the goal was to pool resources for user profiles that are hard to find.

Researchers outlined the following aspects to build upon this issue:

- Target personas
- Types of studies to use the screener
- Study formats
- Product stages

Tips and tricks

- You can mix and match recruiting sources. For example, you may recruit some participants from the panel and some from other sources, so that you don't over sample from your panel. Do not use the same person more than four times in a year for a study.
- Build rapport with your panelists. Since you may talk to them more than once, you can build a connection with them.
- Consider sending out research participation requests in waves, rather than sending to your entire list. For example, if you have a panel of 1,000 users, send research participation requests in waves of 100, so that you don't exhaust the entire panel all at once.
- When in doubt, ask. If you have questions or doubts on any aspect of starting or managing a panel, ping the uxreops channel for advice.

SECTION: product/ux/ux-research/research-shadowing.md

All new Product Managers and Product Designers should go through this research shadowing process as a part of their onboarding before conducting independent research.

This research shadowing process is intended to ensure that stable counterparts have sufficient understanding to be able to undertake UX research independently. Counterparts will read through training materials and observe the execution of a UX research study all the way through from planning to analysis. They will be paired with a UX Researcher that can answer any questions they have and provide support during this process.

Shadower process

1. Identify the UX Researcher assigned to your stage group. This person will be your contact during this shadow process. Reach out to them and introduce yourself and let them know you're starting research shadowing.

1. Read through pages that are relevant to you and your project(s) within the UX Research handbook section. Your researcher can answer any questions you may have.

Problem Validation shadowing

1. Once you start the shadow process, the researcher will identify an upcoming problem validation study they feel will be suitable for you to shadow.

- If the researcher won't be conducting any suitable research in the near future, they may coordinate with you to observe a study being conducted by another researcher.

1. Once your researcher has identified an appropriate study, they'll start including you on each part of the research process. This will include things like the research plan, discussion guide, etc.

- Read through these materials as they're created, and ping the researcher with any questions you have.

1. You'll be added to research sessions as they're scheduled. You'll observe, take notes, and participate in any debrief that happens. Let the researcher know which sessions you'll observe.

- You should attend at least two sessions. If you want to observe more than that you can work it out with the researcher.

1. The researcher will include you on any analysis of the research and send you the final insights document.

1. Once the study has concluded, the researcher will reach out for a final check-in. Use this time to ask any remaining questions you have. At this point, you should have enough understanding to conduct research on your own.

Solution Validation shadowing

1. When conducting your first solo Solution Validation at GitLab, you will need to have a researcher (preferably from your group or section) shadow your first solution interview.

- This is to ensure you get feedback about your approach, and that a UX Researcher and your Product Design Manager are aware so they can support you.

1. Solution Validation is conducted by the Product Designer and PM counterpart.

1. The role of research in Solution Validation is to provide an initial framework and to provide feedback on the goals of your study.

1. After a researcher has shadowed your interview (either live or by watching the recording), they will provide written feedback to you and cc your Product Design Manager.

UX Researcher process

1. When a new hire reaches out to you to start the research shadow process, start thinking about what upcoming research study would be suitable for the shadower to observe. If there are multiple new hires coming on around the same time you can batch them together to optimize your time and effort. The study you choose for shadowing should be somewhat "standard," with as few atypical elements as possible. If you don't have any suitable studies happening in approximately the next month and a half, you may need to transfer responsibility to another researcher. Ask your manager if you're unsure.

1. Once you've identified the study, start including the shadower on each part of the research process. Tag them in issues and share documents like the discussion guide with them. Be available to answer any questions they may have. The goal is that they have a clear idea how to execute each phase of the research process.

1. As you schedule sessions, include the shadower on the invites. They should let you know what

sessions they plan to observe, with a minimum of two.

1. Be sure to include the shadower on any analysis documents as well as any findings produced.
1. Once the study has concluded, reach out to the shadower for a final check-in. This is their last chance to ask whatever questions they still have. After this point the shadower will be considered ready to execute research on their own.

SECTION: product/ux/ux-research/research-tools.md

Product Managers, Product Designers, and UX Researchers have access to the UX research tools below. If you need access to any of these tools, please open an access request.

Research tools we use

- Calendly is used for scheduling research sessions with users. A basic plan (free) is usually adequate for Product Managers and Product Designers. UX Researchers are entitled to a Premium account. Should you wish to upgrade your Calendly account to Premium, please contact @karenlyi.
- Qualtrics: CoreXM with TextiQ is used for surveys and screening surveys. For further information about Qualtrics, including how to create and style your survey, please visit Qualtrics tips & tricks.
- Dovetail is used to analyze data, collaborate on insights, and as a research repository.
- Optimal Workshop is used to facilitate card sort testing and tree testing. We do not have an ongoing subscription, so a monthly license is purchased as needed. Contact @karenlyi first to discuss next steps.
- UserTesting.com is used for certain unmoderated testing for solution validation and Category Maturity Scorecard studies. Note: UserTesting.com offers analysis tools but we prefer exporting the videos to Dovetail for analysis to keep a SSOT.
- Respondent.io is used for moderated testing for problem validation studies. We typically use Respondent.io to find participants if we're having challenges in finding participants within our own internal panel.
- Figjam is used for online brainstorming, synthesis, and collaboration.

SECTION: product/ux/ux-research/solution-validation-and-methods.md

At GitLab, we practice both Problem Validation and Solution Validation research, depending on the questions we need answers to and where we are in the design process. The end result of these methods is a high degree of confidence that results in a better overall user experience.

What is Solution Validation?

After identifying and understanding a problem, its context, and the people around it (also known as problem validation) the next step is to learn which solutions will work and which ones do not. Solution validation research critically assesses if the product/feature/design has indeed solved the problem that was initially intended to be solved.

When to use Solution Validation?

Solution validation happens later on in the product life cycle when we want to get feedback on potential solutions or solutions made available to users.

Solution validation research is conducted after we have a working design or prototype that was created to solve the problem(s) discovered in Problem Validation research. It is not necessary for the design or prototype to be high fidelity, it only needs to be able to support the task(s) it was designed for.

You can and should conduct solution validation research when confidence in the proposed solution isn't high, as it can help identify issues that may have been missed during other stages of the project. A great way to increase the confidence in your solution is to base design decisions on prior user research.

Apply the UX Solution Validation label to your research issue in the GitLab UX Research project.

What questions can Solution Validation answer?

- How do participants leverage the new product/feature/design to achieve a task?
- What pain points exist?
- What other information should be made available to ensure task success?
- Does the product/design/feature meet the user's expectations?
- Which design allows the best task completion?
- How does the new product/design/feature impact user's existing workflows?

Different Solution Validation research methods

When choosing the appropriate methodology for your research question, there are multiple factors to consider.

If you choose to conduct Usability Testing, take advantage of our tips on how to write a usability testing script. We also have an unmoderated usability testing tool, UserTesting.com.

There is a UX Cloud Sandbox which is a reserved instance of GitLab for UX testing and research. The referenced handbook page has everything you need to get started, and there is also a ux-cloud-sandbox Slack channel to reach out to for help.

If you want help creating a pristine test environment separate from the sandbox be sure to reach out to the Demo Systems group on the demo-systems Slack channel. They can create a demo environment for users and help build any particular parameters needed for your testing environment. Be aware that setting up a test environment for a research study this way can be time consuming and difficult.

To choose the right solution validation research method, you need to identify the purpose for your research. Ask yourself "What information do I need to learn to increase my confidence in the design?" Your answer will help you choose which method to use. If you are still unsure, please reach out to your UX Researcher.

	Overall Purpose for Research
Research Method	

```
|:-----|
-----|:-----|
| <ul><li>Evaluate a change to a feature and/or process</li> <li>Evaluate how well a current
design supports user's goals</li></ul> | Usability Testing      |
| <ul><li>Understand how the current information architecture performs</li> <li>Learn if the
current labels make sense to users</li> <li>Learn if users can find the information they need
easily and quickly</li></ul> | Tree Testing <br>Card Sorting      |
| <ul><li>Identify usability concerns within a specific workflow</li> <li>Scope and track the
effort of addressing usability concerns within a specific workflow</li></ul>
| UX Scorecard |
| <ul><li>Verify that the first click a user makes on an interface is the intended starting
point for a given workflow or a navigation element</li></ul>
| First Click Testing |
```

SECTION: product/ux/ux-research/tracking-actionable-insights.md

At GitLab, we track actionable insights derived from UX research studies. These can be in the form of Exploration needed or Product change.

Actionable insights that are tracked will have one of the following labels:

- Actionable insight::Exploration needed
- Actionable insight::Product change

The labels are used to generate this dashboard (internal only), which informs us of the following:

- The number of issues closed and the number of issues opened during this month (Velocity)
- The volume of newly created actionable insights, by quarter

Collectively, these data visualizations helps us understand more about incoming volume and lifespan of actionable insights.

SECTION: product/ux/ux-research/tracking-research-projects.md

As part of our UX research prioritization process, each UX research project issue will have one of the following labels:

- UX Research Prioritization: Gold
- UX Research Prioritization: Silver
- UX Research Prioritization: Bronze

The labels are used to generate this dashboard (internal only), which informs us of the following:

- Total number of new UX research projects opened each quarter, by service level

- Total number of new UX research projects opened each quarter, by stage
- Average number of days it takes to complete a UX research project by service level
- Total number of open UX research projects, by service level

Collectively, these data visualizations helps us understand more about the volume of UX research occurring, the lifecycle of a UX research project, and where UX research projects are taking place.

SECTION: product/ux/ux-research/tracking-research-velocity.md

Research issues that are actual research efforts/projects should have one of the following labels:

- CM scorecard
- UX solution validation
- UX problem validation

The labels are used to generate this report, which is a Key Performance Indicator for the UX team. When you finish the issue, close it out and leave the label applied. You can un-assign yourself if you want. Make sure you only use this label once per research initiative.

SECTION: product/ux/ux-research/unmoderated-testing.md

At GitLab, we use UserTesting.com for certain unmoderated testing for Solution Validation and Category Maturity Scorecard studies. Unmoderated usability testing allows us to obtain evaluative feedback from our users very quickly, thereby allowing us to iterate faster in a more independent manner that requires fewer resources.

What is unmoderated usability testing?

Unmoderated usability testing is defined as a way to conduct usability testing without a moderator being present. That means the participant will go through all of the tasks/instructions/questions solo. This is typically accomplished through a service that also has a panel of participants. The output of an unmoderated usability study are videos, which have to be watched and analyzed by the person who kicked-off the research.

GitLab and UserTesting.com

For awareness, we don't have an unlimited amount of studies we can conduct with UserTesting.com, so please consider that when launching studies on UserTesting.com.

Pros and cons

It's important to note that there are pros and cons to using unmoderated testing, and those should be considered before deciding to go with unmoderated vs. moderated. To illustrate:

Unmoderated

- Pros:
 - Very fast turnaround time (hours)
 - No coordination needed for scheduling or gratuities
 - Large, diverse participant panel
- Cons:
 - Can't talk to participants to get them back on track or to confirm if they understand the task
 - Requires a clear set of tasks/instructions/questions

Moderated

- Pros:
 - Able to have discussions with participants and go deep into an observed behavior
 - Can course correct if needed
- Cons:
 - Time consuming (weeks)
 - Requires scheduling and gratuity coordination

Best practices for your study

- Always launch your study with 1-2 participants first. These serve as your pilot, and you'll use these results to determine whether participants understand your tasks and questions. The worst thing you can do is launch the study with all 5-8 participants only to find out that they interpreted your tasks and questions in a different way than you intended.
- If you're asking rating questions, ask "why did you rate it that way?" Since we're dealing with qualitative data, you'll want to understand the why behind those ratings.
- Screen carefully and wisely. Unmoderated testers get paid per study, so the more studies they take part in, the more they get paid. As a result, sometimes you'll get participants who may have lied their way through the screener just to get a study. To reduce the chances of that from happening, there's a handbook page on how to write an effective screener.
- Studies should not be too long. A good guide is that the test should range between 15-20 mins. This can be gauged by going through the test in preview mode and with the small sample of 1-2 participants. For quicker tests consider using the short test format.

Best practices for your prototype

If using Figma for your prototype, there are a few tips to keep in mind before attaching the link to your test:

- Set the prototype to Fit to screen to fill the participant's screen.
- Uncheck Show hotspot hints on click. Often participants know to search for these which may bias testing results.
- Even after disabling hotspot hints, the cursor changes while hovering over a clickable area in Figma. Try to provide some additional mock clickable options to users in the prototype to avoid making the main click option obvious for them.
- Uncheck Show Figma UI. This will allow the participants to focus only on your prototype without seeing extra information.
- Ensure that the sharing settings allow the participant to view the prototype, and only the

prototype.

- Participants are able to view the name of the prototype in the tab, so avoid including any priming information here.

Frequently Asked Questions

- How do I know if my study is a good candidate for unmoderated testing? If your study doesn't require you to explain details and if there's low risk of participants veering off course, your study is probably a good candidate for unmoderated testing. If you have any questions as to whether a study is a good fit for unmoderated testing, ask your UX Researcher.
- What if I want to ask problem validation related questions? UserTesting.com isn't your best option. Instead, go through the recruitment process to identify participants in other ways.
- How many participants should I request per study? Since we're using unmoderated for evaluation studies, the sample size should be between 5-8 participants per study.
- Can I create a custom panel of existing GitLab users? While it is possible to create a custom panel, we recommend using the UserTesting panel and use the screener questions that are already saved for you to screen for GitLab users in specific roles.
- Can I screen for certain criteria? Of course - whatever you want. The stricter the screener criteria, the less likely you are to find the participants you're looking for. Note that there are already some GitLab screening questions in UserTesting.com for you to utilize. You can find them under the 'Saved Screener Questions' within UserTesting.com.
- How do the demographic filters work with all those checkboxes? The way the demographic filters work is as follows: If no filter is selected, the pool of participants would include anyone in the UserTesting.com panel. When you start selecting filters, the pool of participants becomes specific to the filters you are looking for, hence a smaller pool of potential testers. Not selecting any filters does not exclude anyone from the study, on the contrary, you will target more participants in this manner. It's recommended to keep the demographic filters as general as possible and then use the screener questions to find the specific type of participant you are looking for.
- Do I have to ask certain screening questions, to meet GitLab's requirements? Yes. At the very least, you must ask the 'Individual contributor license agreement' question - and possibly the IP Assignment question. Both of which are already saved as a 'Saved Screener Question' within UserTesting.com for you to add to your screening criteria.
- I ended up with a not-so-great participant (for example, they didn't meet the screening criteria, they weren't very vocal, or they didn't follow instructions, etc.). What do I do? Within UserTesting.com, you have the ability to rate your participants on a 5-star scale. If you rate them as 1-star, UserTesting.com Support will reach out to you and ask if you would like a replacement participant. You can either say yes or ask for credit instead.
- Do I have to worry about how many times I use UserTesting.com? You should be aware that we have a limited number of 'units' that we use within the year. It's not an unlimited number of units. However, you are encouraged to utilize UserTesting.com as much as you need to.
- How do I get an account? Through an Access Request. UserTesting.com seats are allocated only to Product Designers and UX Researchers at this time, since those are the disciplines that are closely involved with solution validation and Category Maturity Scorecard testing.
- How do recruitment and gratuities work? When recruiting through the UserTesting.com panel, gratuities are taken care of. You don't have to worry about that step at all.
- What's the output of a UserTesting.com study? Video clips and a summary of the data, if survey questions were asked. Video clips can be downloaded to be used in Dovetail.
- I'm not finding the kinds of participants I need in the UserTesting.com panel. What do I do? Reach out to @asmolinski2. Note that gratuities would have to be handled by the UX Researcher,

though.

- What's a 'short test'? I see this option in UserTesting when I'm building my study. A 'short test' a feature in UserTesting that allows you to conduct short studies, consisting of 3-5 questions. These are perfect to answer lightweight research questions that you need an answer to. An example might be a first-click study where you want to learn where participants click within a screenshot or workflow. The length of the study should not exceed 5 mins. The benefit to using a short test: it consumes half the amount of credits a standard UserTesting study would consume.
- I have so many questions! Who can I reach out to with them? First, try looking in UserTesting.com's training materials (UserTesting login required). If that doesn't help, ask in the Slack channel [uxresearchusertesting](#).
- Should we "Enable Participant View" in UserTesting.com? Enabling this setting will capture the participant's facial expressions as they work through the study and give you more insight into how they feel. However it is not mandatory to enable this setting. Consider adding a multiple-choice (single select) question or verbal question asking them about the confidence in their action, if that is the data you were hoping to get on camera.
- Do we have a template I could use to quick start my study? Yes, check out account templates and choose one from there.
- How do I eliminate question order bias in a study? When trying to assess prototype A vs. prototype B, you can use a balanced comparison to alternate the order that participants see the variants to reduce the risk of ordering bias on results.

SECTION: [product/ux/ux-research/usability-benchmarking.md](#)

According to the Nielsen/Norman Group, usability or user experience benchmarking is "the process of evaluating a product or service's user experience by using metrics to gauge its relative performance against a meaningful standard." While benchmarking can require a good amount of time and effort, there are few alternate research methods that provide both the same volume of data and granularity of insights. This page describes the processes and considerations that we put into usability benchmarking at GitLab.

Why conduct a usability benchmarking study

Usability benchmarking takes a collection of related workflows, breaks them down into discrete tasks, and measures how usable they are across several dimensions. What this generates is a rich body of quantitative and qualitative data that highlights specific pain points and areas for improvement. These pain points can then be turned into actionable insights which will improve the overall usability of a product. By performing a usability benchmarking study, you give your team validated, granular recommendations for making your product better.

When to benchmark

Benchmarking can be a useful method for generating longitudinal, quantitative comparisons (for example, tracking the time it takes to complete a task before and after a significant change to the user interface). Because of the benefits of running benchmarking studies several times, it can be useful to think of benchmarking as a research program, as opposed to a one-off activity. This is how we tend to think of it at GitLab.

Benchmarking at GitLab

Benchmarking is a thorough and time-intensive undertaking that requires a high degree of rigor from the research lead. This page lists guidelines and best practices to ensure the quality and uniformity of our benchmarking efforts and measures, while also reducing 'start-up costs' for new benchmarking efforts.

Anatomy

Every benchmarking study has a similar 'skeleton' - the basic elements one needs in order to successfully run the study. Typically, these are:

- Protocol: The blueprint for each session that you run. This includes the things you (or the moderator) will say to each participant to introduce and explain the study, including each question you will ask and in what order. It generally serves as the script by which you conduct each session.
- Tasks: These are the discrete tasks that you will ask the participant to perform and that you will measure for your study.
- Metrics: Before your study begins, be explicit about what data you are gathering, which metrics you plan to report on, and the reasoning behind your methodology. With usability benchmarking, it's important to report out the same metrics being used across other benchmarks. However, additional metrics can also be reported out at the stage level if they add value.
- Timeline: Planning, conducting, and analyzing a benchmarking study takes time. Creating a timeline for yourself and your stakeholders keeps the study on track and keeps your team informed.

Planning for a benchmarking study

When leading a benchmarking study, you will need to coordinate with several stakeholders including the Product Manager (PM) and Product Designer (PD) to ensure that everyone agrees upon the study protocol, tasks, metrics, and timeline. As with any UX research project that you're driving, don't forget to share the test plan with the UX Research team for a peer review.

The early planning stages are crucial for setting the rest of your study up for success. In order to maximize the first few weeks of study planning, communicate with your stakeholders on how they would prefer to provide feedback. If you are getting feedback async, make sure to provide firm deadlines that are non-negotiable. In cases where those deadlines are not being met, try pivoting to sync communication such as a scheduled meeting to help stay on the research timeline.

Sample and recruiting

You will want to consider your sample when recruiting for a usability benchmark study. While there are not set guidelines for the sample, you want to consider a general mix of participants across these factors:

- Persona(s) relevant to the area the study covers to make sure that you're testing with your target users.
- Company size that the participant works for, as that can influence the types of tasks that

users typically perform and/or give them better mastery if they're working at Enterprise scale.

- Team size that the participant is directly on. Those on All-in-One teams will have more experience across the platform and will likely be more skilled at any tasks as they have a better understanding of how aspect of the platform work together. Team size greatly impacts how users interact with GitLab.
- SaaS vs Self-Managed license type for the company that the participant works for. Self-Managed users may be working with earlier versions of GitLab which might impact their performance.
- GitLab tenure for the individual participant. Those with more experience with GitLab have background knowledge to assist them on completing tasks. You may want to explicitly sample newer or brand-new users depending on the workflows and/or tasks. Generally, obtaining a mixture is good practice.
- Industry verticle of the company that the participant works for. Different industries may approach tasks in a different manner.
- Individual experience in their role, exclusive of their GitLab tenure. Those with more experience in their role will bring different background knowledge to completing tasks.
- Interface preference that the participant works in. Dependent on their preference some participants will use GitLab's web UI or the terminal. This will impact how they approach tasks.

You want to try to avoid over indexing on participants from any one of these factors. For example, avoid sampling all participants that have Self-Managed licensing. When opening your recruitment issue, describe your ideal target sample for your benchmark so that the Research Operations Coordinator can best match their recruitment efforts.

Protocol

Each protocol is tailored to the topic and specifics of the study it belongs to, but often contains similar sections. Generally, you will want to cover the following (many of these are common to all moderated studies):

- Welcome the participant, and thank them for taking the time to help you out.
- Ensure they have provided consent to be recorded and for the recordings to be shared internally within GitLab.
- Explain why they are here, and offer a high-level overview of what the study is about.
- Ask warm-up questions about what their day-to-day is like, how long they've been using GitLab, and any other 'softball' questions to help get into rhythm.
- Explain the session. For benchmarking, this entails laying out how you're going to run each task, describing the behaviors that are encouraged or discouraged (for example, talking aloud is not usually done in benchmarking), and generally laying out the structure of what the participant can expect during your time together.

The Usability Benchmarking template contains some boilerplate language to work off of for your own study.

Tasks

A few guidelines when selecting tasks for your study:

- Relate every task to a Job To Be Done for one of our personas.

- Review SUS feedback to identify areas that users provide negative feedback on. This is a useful exercise for two reasons:

1) To help in task creation - If there are pain points identified through SUS, or other feedback mechanisms, it's good practice to look for opportunities where your tasks can explore them further. Doing so allows you to witness the pain points in person and understand more details around them.

2) For data triangulation - After you analyze the benchmark data, you will have identified pain points through your tasks. You can use SUS data to understand if the pain points you identified in your benchmark were also seen in the SUS feedback. This is useful, because triangulation can help strengthen insights; for example, we can state "this pain point was also a theme in our SUS feedback in Q1." If the benchmark pain points weren't previously identified through SUS feedback, that's also worth pointing out and exploring further.

- Group individual tasks by workflow and in a sensible order (for example, don't have a 'close issue' task before an 'open issue' task).

- Determine a happy medium of complexity for tasks. Too easy is not meaningful. Too complex makes measuring specific parts of a workflow difficult.

- Consider setting a 'cut off' time limit for each task to ensure you get through all of them.

- Be careful. when describing tasks to the participant. Use language that is accurate but doesn't align exactly with UI text, so that you don't unintentionally lead participants to the right answer.

- Go through each yourself, and record the 'happy' or expected path. Get confirmation from your stakeholders if you are uncertain.

- Recruit 1 or 2 pilot participants to test out the task instructions, so you can make modifications if users are too unclear on what they need to do.

- Enumerate the completion criteria for each task. This will serve as a checklist of sorts to ensure you are consistent when recording completion.

- Identify all of the ways users can complete a task. In some cases, GitLab offers different routes to the same outcome (for example, users can approve a deployment on two unique pages in the UI, so either option would count as a successful task).

- Consider applying a weight or points to each task to help calculate priority or severity.

Here is an example of a singular task as written in the task list:

| Name | Example |

| ----- | ----- |

| Task Code | BRANCHOPS3 |

| Topic | Branch Operations |

| Task | Protect Branch |

| Cut off time | 5:00 |

| Description | Make this branch a protected branch, where devs and maintainers can merge, push, and force push. |

| Notes | Must be 'maintainer' role or higher. Will need to find project settings. Push rules are also allowed in GitLab Enterprise Edition. |

| Related JTBD | When product improvements are identified, I want to propose changes that address them, so that I can help build a better product. |

| Happy Path | Left nav, settings -> repository. Find protected branches section, click expand. Under protect a branch section, use dropdown to select 'newbranch'. In 'allowed to merge' and 'allowed to push' dropdowns, select 'Developers + Maintainers'. Toggle 'allowed to force push' to on. Click 'protect' button. |

| Completion Criteria | ·Correct branch is protected
 ·Allowed to merge checked

·Allowed to push checked
 ·Force push toggled
 ·Protect button clicked |
| Weight | 5 |

A note on cut-off time

There isn't a hard and fast rule when it comes to assigning a cut-off time for your tasks. There are a few ways you might do this:

- Time yourself completing the tasks, and, if you're an expert, multiply that by 3 (a guideline for how long a novice might take).
 - Perform a KLM (Keystroke Level Modeling) calculation to get a rough estimate of time on task.
 - Run a pilot without enforcing any cut off. Measure time on task, and use that as a baseline.
- This comes with some caveats: you should consider adding time to the tasks that your pilot participant completed quickly and possibly subtracting time from